INSTRUCTIONAL AREA
Earning Income

PERSONAL FINANCIAL LITERACY EVENT

PARTICIPANT INSTRUCTIONS

(quoted directly from DECA, INC)

- "This event is presented to you through your review of the Career Competencies, Performance Indicators and Event Situation."
- "You have up to 10 minutes to review this information and prepare your presentation. Using the materials provided, you may make notes to use during your presentation."
- "You will have up to 10 minutes to present to the judge(s)."
- "You will be evaluated on your solution to the event situation, how you incorporate the performance indicators of this event and how you demonstrate the career competencies."
- "Turn in all your notes and event materials when you have completed the event."

SOLUTION

- Unique – Demonstrate original thinking, fresh perspectives and an insightful approach.
- Practical – Develop an actionable/viable solution in a real-world context.
- Effective – Develop a solution that achieves relevant outcomes.

CAREER COMPETENCIES

- Critical Thinking – Think critically to understand and solve problems.
- Communication – Communicate clearly, effectively and with reason.
- Decision Making – Consider the impacts of decisions.

PERFORMANCE INDICATORS

1. Discuss how economic and labor market conditions can affect income, career opportunities, and employment status.
2. Explain why people should evaluate employee benefits in addition to wages and salaries when choosing between job and career opportunities.
3. Explain how taxes impact take-home pay.

EVENT SITUATION

You are to assume the role of a career and financial coach at TRI-COUNTY CAREER CENTER, a workforce development office. A client (judge) recently lost their job and wants help choosing between two offers.

The client (judge) worked for five years as a customer support specialist for a software company. Two months ago, the company replaced most of its support team with an AI chatbot and laid off the client (judge) and 40 coworkers. The client (judge) now has two offers:

Option A: Customer Success Associate, PINEWOOD HEALTH SYSTEM (full-time employee)

- $46,000 annual salary
- Health insurance, with the employer paying 80% of the premium
- 401(k) retirement plan with a 4% employer match
- 15 paid days off per year
- Up to $2,000 per year in tuition and training reimbursement
- Taxes withheld from each paycheck

Option B: Freelance AI Chat Trainer, through an online work platform (independent contractor)

- $32 per hour, with an estimated 35 hours per week (about $58,000 per year if work stays steady)
- No health insurance, retirement plan or paid time off
- No taxes withheld; the client (judge) would have to pay self-employment tax and make quarterly estimated tax payments
- Weekly hours depend on how much work the platform has, and the platform can end the arrangement at any time

The client (judge) is leaning toward Option B because “the number is bigger.” The client (judge) wants you to explain how economic and labor market changes like AI are affecting jobs and income, why benefits matter as much as pay, and how taxes would affect take-home pay under each option.

You will present the information to the client (judge) in a meeting at the career center. The client (judge) will begin the meeting by greeting you and asking about the offers. After you have presented the information and answered the client’s (judge’s) questions, the client (judge) will conclude the meeting by thanking you for your work.

Possible Judge's Questions:

1. If nobody takes taxes out of my freelance pay, what happens if I just pay everything at tax time?
2. The freelance job pays about $12,000 more a year. Why wouldn't I just take the higher number?

	Rate the participants' ability to:	Novice	Developing	Proficient	Exemplary	Judged Score
PERFORMANCE INDICATORS						
1.	Discuss how economic and labor market conditions can affect income, career opportunities, and employment status.	0-1-2-3-4-5	6-7-8-9-10-11	12-13-14-15-16	17	
2.	Explain why people should evaluate employee benefits in addition to wages and salaries when choosing between job and career opportunities.	0-1-2-3-4-5	6-7-8-9-10-11	12-13-14-15-16	17	
3.	Explain how taxes impact take-home pay.	0-1-2-3-4-5	6-7-8-9-10-11	12-13-14-15-16	17	
SOLUTION						
4.	**Unique** Demonstrate original thinking, fresh perspectives and an insightful approach.	0-1-2	3-4-5	6-7	8	
5.	**Practical** Develop an actionable/viable solution in a real-world context.	0-1-2	3-4-5	6-7	8	
6.	**Effective** Develop a solution that achieves relevant outcomes	0-1-2	3-4-5	6-7	8	
CAEREER COMPETANCIES						
7.	**Critical Thinking** Think critically to understand and solve problems	0-1	2-3	4-5	6	
8.	**Communication** Communicate clearly, effectively and with reason.	0-1	2-3	4-5	6	
9.	**Decision Making** Consider the impacts of decisions.	0-1	2-3	4-5	6	
OVERALL IMPRESSIONS						
10.	Demonstrate overall career readiness through professionalism, poise and confidence.	0-1-2	3-4	5-6	7	
					TOTAL SCORE	